THE PRESIDENCY



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

As Droupadi Murmu stood up to take the presidential oath administered by Chief Justice N.V. Ramana on July 25, a hush descended on the power-packed audience that included the prime minister and over a dozen chief ministers assembled in the Central Hall of Parliament to bear witness to this moment in history. Once she was sworn in as the 15th President of India, though, the hall, with life-sized portraits of national icons, former presidents and prime ministers looking on, reverberated with the sounds of loud clapping and chants of '*Bharat Mata ki jai*'. Prime Minister Narendra Modi would later describe it "as a watershed moment for India, especially for the poor, marginalised and downtrodden".

Indeed, it was. The journey of a shy, quiet Santhali girl from the rustic settings of Odisha's Rairangpur to the presidential mansion on Raisina Hill is more than just a rags to Rashtrapati Bhavan story. It is an inspiring narrative of how someone born on the margins of society overcame all hurdles and struggles with an indomitable and tireless spirit to earn a place in the country's history. As Murmu said in her first address to Parliament soon after becoming President, "It is a tribute to the power of our democracy that a daughter born in a poor house in a remote tribal area can reach the highest constitutional position in India."

The symbolism of her achievement is ginormous. Murmu became the first Adivasi or tribal, the second woman and, at 64, the youngest ever to be appointed President of India. India's tribals total around 110 million people or close to nine per cent of its population, with 80 per cent of them living in clusters across nine of India's 28 states. There are over 700 recognised tribes, but only two of them—the Bhils and Gonds—have populations of over 10 million, and 30 others number more than half a million each. They occupy much of India's heartland, but are also spread out to as far as Kashmir in th2e north, Kanyakumari in the south, the Dangs in the west, Mayurbhanj in the east and Itanagar in the Northeast. Like the scheduled castes, who are double their size in terms of population, Indian tribals enjoy reservation in government educational institutions and jobs, in addition to reserved seats in parliamentary and assembly constituencies. However, unlike the Dalits, who have been able to